

Trail Angels

Volunteer Stories 2023–2026

ESC Project 101093414 · Tuscany, Italy

Centro Nazionale per il Volontariato · Lucca

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Trail Angels: A Journey of Volunteering, Solidarity and Connection in Tuscany

2026 | Tuscany, Italy

Some projects begin with an idea and slowly become something much bigger than anyone originally imagined. Trail Angels is one of those projects.

Between 2023 and 2026, young people from different countries came together in Tuscany through the European Solidarity Corps with a shared purpose: to contribute their time and energy to protecting the environment, caring for historic walking routes and supporting the communities that welcomed them.

Over the course of the project, different international teams became part of the Trail Angels story. Each group arrived with its own energy, personalities, languages and cultures, but the idea connecting them remained the same. Volunteering was not only about travelling somewhere new. It was about becoming part of a place, contributing to it and leaving something positive behind.

Much of the Trail Angels journey took place outdoors, along the historic paths and natural areas of Tuscany. Volunteers worked together to clear vegetation, remove branches and debris, collect litter and help keep walking routes accessible and welcoming.

The work was often simple and practical, but its impact could be seen immediately. A path that needed attention could look completely different after a group of volunteers had spent time working together. Bags of rubbish disappeared from natural areas, overgrown sections became easier to walk, and the landscapes surrounding the trails received the care they needed.

Behind these activities was an important idea: the places we enjoy are also places we have a responsibility to protect.

For the Trail Angels, this responsibility became closely connected with the Via Francigena, one of Europe's most historic pilgrimage routes. For centuries, people have travelled along these paths, and today walkers and pilgrims from around the world continue to follow them through Tuscany.

Working along these routes gave the volunteers the opportunity to meet some of the people travelling them. These encounters often provided a simple reminder of why maintaining the paths matters. Every clean section of trail and every small improvement can become part of someone else's journey.

In 2024, this curiosity about the people walking the route developed into Pilgrim Talks, a three-part interview series created together with the European Association of the Via Francigena. Instead of simply watching pilgrims pass by, the volunteers stopped to listen to their stories.

They discovered people walking for many different reasons. Some were searching for adventure, others were taking on personal challenges, and some were simply looking for a different way to experience the world. Every person brought a different story to the same road.

The volunteers also collected practical information that could be useful to future walkers, including information about water points and places to rest. By bringing this information together in a map, the team was able to transform its own experience on the trail into something that could support other people travelling the route.

Environmental action remained one of the strongest elements of Trail Angels throughout the project. Clean-up activities repeatedly showed how much waste can accumulate along walking routes and in natural areas. Volunteers collected bag after bag of litter, sometimes surprised by how much could be found in places that appeared untouched at first sight.

These activities also became an opportunity to communicate a wider message about environmental responsibility. Cleaning a path is important, but preventing rubbish from reaching it in the first place is even better. Through their work and communication activities, the Trail Angels encouraged others to respect the environment and remember that protecting shared natural spaces is everyone's responsibility.

As the project developed, the volunteers also discovered different sides of Tuscany. Beyond the places most commonly associated with the region, they experienced forests, countryside, historic paths and quieter natural areas. Walking and volunteering provided a completely different perspective from conventional tourism. Instead of simply visiting a destination, the volunteers spent time getting to know the landscapes and communities around them.

This slower way of experiencing Tuscany became an important part of the Trail Angels story. It showed that travelling can also mean taking the time to walk, observe and connect with a place rather than simply moving from one attraction to another.

Some volunteers shared these experiences through online content and podcast episodes, giving others an opportunity to hear directly what international volunteering was like. Photos, videos and stories also helped bring the experience beyond Tuscany and introduce more young people to environmental volunteering and the opportunities available through the European Solidarity Corps.

However, not everything that made Trail Angels meaningful happened on the trails. An equally important part of the project happened in kitchens, shared houses and around dinner tables.

Every new group brought together young people who often came from completely different backgrounds. They arrived speaking different languages and carrying different habits, expectations and ideas about everyday life. Suddenly, they had to learn how to live together.

There were groceries to buy, meals to prepare and responsibilities to share. There were cultural differences to navigate and misunderstandings to solve. Sometimes there was chaos, but there was also plenty of laughter.

Cultural evenings became opportunities for volunteers to introduce their countries through food, traditions and stories. At other times, cultural exchange happened naturally during an ordinary dinner or conversation. These everyday moments became just as important as the organised activities.

People who arrived as strangers learned how to cooperate. They discovered things about countries they may never have visited and cultures they may previously have known very little about. Friendships developed between people whose paths might never have crossed without the European Solidarity Corps.

In this way, Trail Angels became a project about the environment, but also about people. It was about learning that solidarity can take many forms. Sometimes it means spending hours outdoors cleaning a trail. Sometimes it means supporting a local activity or helping at a community event. Sometimes it simply means noticing where help is needed and being willing to contribute.

As the volunteers became more connected with the communities around them, their role could also extend beyond the original environmental activities. Taking part in local volunteering initiatives and supporting community events created opportunities for international volunteers to meet people who had been contributing to their communities for years.

These moments showed that international volunteering does not need to exist separately from local life. When volunteers are given the opportunity to participate, listen and contribute, they can become part of a community rather than simply visitors passing through it.

Looking at the Trail Angels journey from 2023 to 2026, its story is ultimately made up of many small actions. It is found in every bag of rubbish removed from nature, every path cleared and every walker who finds the route a little easier to follow. It is found in

conversations with pilgrims and in the stories they shared. It is found in the volunteers who arrived in Tuscany without knowing one another and left with friendships that crossed borders.

It is found in shared meals, cultural evenings, difficult working days, spontaneous adventures and all the ordinary moments that never appear in an official project description but often become the memories people keep for the longest.

The historic paths running through Tuscany existed long before the first Trail Angels arrived, and people will continue to walk them long into the future. The contribution of one volunteering project may represent only a small chapter in their much longer history. But small contributions matter.

Between 2023 and 2026, young people from different parts of Europe and beyond came to Tuscany and chose to give their time to something they believed was worthwhile. Together, they helped care for the environment, supported walking routes, contributed to local communities and shared their experiences with others. At the same time, they learned from one another and discovered what it means to build a community across languages, cultures and borders.

Perhaps this is the most important result of Trail Angels. The project shows that solidarity does not always need to begin with something extraordinary. It can begin with a group of people putting on their gloves and deciding to clean a path together. From there, it can grow into conversations, friendships, cultural exchange and a feeling of connection with a place that was once completely unfamiliar.

The trails remain, waiting for the next people to walk them. And wherever the Trail Angels go next, a small part of their story will remain in Tuscany — along the paths they walked, in the places they helped to care for and in the communities they became part of along the way.

To every volunteer, partner, community member, pilgrim and person who contributed to this journey: thank you for being part of the Trail Angels story.

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The Trail Angels Journey Begins

2023 | Tuscany, Italy

In 2023, a new adventure began in Tuscany as the first team of Trail Angels came together through the European Solidarity Corps. Young people from different countries and backgrounds arrived with the same goal: to spend their time doing something meaningful for the environment while discovering a new place and experiencing international community life.

The main focus of the project was caring for the historic walking routes that cross Tuscany and the natural environment surrounding them. The volunteers took part in practical outdoor activities, clearing vegetation and branches from the paths, collecting litter and helping to keep the trails clean and accessible for the people who use them.

The work could sometimes be physically demanding, especially under the Tuscan sun, but it was also rewarding to see the results. After working together on a section of a path, the difference was often immediately visible. Knowing that the same path would later be used by walkers and pilgrims gave the activities an additional sense of purpose.

The project also offered an opportunity to learn more about the Via Francigena and the long history behind the routes running through Tuscany. Pilgrims have been following these roads for centuries, and people from all over the world continue to walk them today. By taking care of the trails and their surroundings, the volunteers became part of this ongoing story in their own small way.

Of course, being a Trail Angel was not only about the hours spent outdoors. Living together as an international group quickly became an equally important part of the experience. The volunteers cooked and shopped together, shared responsibilities and spent their free time discovering Tuscany. Evenings often turned into informal cultural exchanges, with everyone sharing stories about their countries, teaching each other words in different languages and learning about traditions they had never encountered before.

As time passed, the group of strangers who had arrived in Tuscany gradually became a real team. New friendships were formed, countless memories were created and the first chapter of the Trail Angels story was written.

The volunteers may eventually return home, but the paths they helped to care for will continue to welcome new walkers and pilgrims. And for the Trail Angels project, this is only the beginning.

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A New Team Continues the Trail Angels Journey

2023 | Tuscany, Italy

The Trail Angels journey continues in Tuscany as a new international group of volunteers comes together to contribute to the protection of the Via Francigena and its surrounding environment.

The volunteers come from different countries, bringing their own languages, cultures and experiences to the project. Although most of them did not know each other before arriving, they quickly found themselves sharing the same daily routine, the same responsibilities and, most importantly, the same goal.

Much of their volunteering takes place outdoors. The team works along the historic walking routes of Tuscany, clearing vegetation, collecting litter and helping to maintain the paths used by pilgrims, local residents and visitors. Walking the routes themselves also gives the volunteers an opportunity to understand why this work is important.

Along the way, the team often encounters pilgrims following the Via Francigena. Some are travelling long distances, while others are exploring only a small part of the route. Meeting them makes the purpose of the volunteering activities much more tangible. A clean and accessible path may seem like a small thing, but for someone who has already spent hours walking, it can make a real difference.

The volunteers are also sharing their experience beyond the project itself. Through photos, videos and online content, they introduce other young people to the Via Francigena, environmental volunteering and the opportunities offered by the European Solidarity Corps. Some of the team's creative content has reached audiences far beyond Tuscany, showing how a local volunteering activity can sometimes have a surprisingly wide impact.

Life together provides another important dimension to the experience. Cultural evenings give volunteers the chance to prepare traditional food and introduce their countries to the rest of the group, while everyday activities such as cooking, shopping and spending evenings together create countless opportunities for spontaneous cultural exchange.

Over time, cultural differences become something to celebrate rather than something separating the group. Everyone brings something different to the experience, and it is precisely this diversity that makes international volunteering so special.

The new team continues the work started by the Trail Angels before them, leaving its own contribution to the paths and communities of Tuscany while creating a completely new set of memories along the way.

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Stories from the Via Francigena

2024 | Tuscany, Italy

In 2024, a new international team of Trail Angels came together in Tuscany to continue caring for the historic paths of the Via Francigena. Surrounded by the Tuscan countryside, the volunteers spent their time helping to keep the routes clean and accessible while also discovering the stories of the people who walk them.

Working along the Via Francigena means regularly meeting pilgrims from different parts of the world. Everyone seems to have a different reason for being there. Some are looking for adventure, others are taking on a personal challenge, and some simply want to slow down and experience the journey one step at a time.

These encounters inspired the team to learn more about the people they were meeting on the road. Together with the European Association of the Via Francigena, the volunteers created Pilgrim Talks, a three-part interview series recorded directly along the route.

The concept was simple: meet pilgrims during their journey and give them an opportunity to tell their stories. The volunteers asked where they had come from, what had inspired them to start walking and what they had discovered along the way. Each conversation offered a different perspective on what it means to travel along such a historic route.

Listening to these stories also changed the way the volunteers looked at their own work. The paths they were helping to clean and maintain were not simply lines crossing the Tuscan countryside. They were places where thousands of personal journeys took place every year. Every section of trail made easier to walk and every piece of litter removed from the environment could improve the experience of someone passing through later.

The team also wanted to create something practical for future travellers. While exploring the route, the volunteers collected useful information about water points and places where walkers could stop and rest. This information was brought together in a map designed to help pilgrims better prepare for their own journeys.

Between volunteering activities and conversations with pilgrims, the Trail Angels were also experiencing a journey of their own. Living together as an international team meant sharing meals, responsibilities, cultural traditions and everyday adventures. People who arrived with different backgrounds and languages gradually found ways to understand one another and build a community.

The Via Francigena is made up of countless individual stories, and for a short time, the story of the Trail Angels became part of it too.

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Keeping Tuscany's Trails Clean

2024 | Tuscany, Italy

One of the most visible challenges along popular walking routes is also one of the most preventable: litter. Plastic bottles, food packaging, cans and other waste can quickly accumulate along paths and in natural areas, affecting both the landscape and the people who come to enjoy it.

In 2024, this became an important focus for the Trail Angels in Tuscany. Equipped with gloves and rubbish bags, the volunteers regularly headed out along the trails to collect waste and help restore the surrounding environment.

The results of these activities were often immediately visible. Bag after bag of rubbish was removed from places where it did not belong, showing both the scale of the problem and how much can be achieved when a group of people decides to take action.

However, the message of the clean-up activities went beyond simply collecting what others had left behind. The volunteers also wanted to encourage walkers, visitors and local communities to think about their own responsibility towards the environment. Historic trails such as the Via Francigena are shared spaces, and protecting them depends on everyone who uses them.

"Help us keep it clean" became a simple message behind many of the team's activities. It was a reminder that caring for nature does not always require complicated solutions. Sometimes, it begins with respecting the places we visit and making sure we leave nothing behind.

Outside the volunteering activities, the international group continued to experience everyday life together in Tuscany. Shared meals, group shopping and cultural evenings became an important part of the project. Volunteers introduced their countries through food, stories and traditions, turning ordinary evenings into opportunities to discover different parts of Europe without leaving the dinner table.

Living together also brought its own lessons in cooperation and solidarity. Sharing responsibilities, adapting to different habits and finding solutions together became part of the experience just as much as the environmental work.

By combining practical action with a simple message about individual responsibility, the Trail Angels hope to leave the paths of Tuscany cleaner and encourage others to think twice before leaving waste behind. After all, keeping these beautiful places clean is something we can all contribute to.

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Discovering a Different Side of Tuscany

2025 | Tuscany, Italy

When people think about Tuscany, they often imagine famous cities, Renaissance art, vineyards and rolling hills. However, beyond these familiar images, there is another side of the region that many visitors never have the opportunity to experience.

In 2025, the Trail Angels are discovering this quieter and greener Tuscany while volunteering along historic walking and pilgrimage routes surrounded by forests, mountains and small communities.

Working in this environment brings its own challenges. The paths can be steep and vegetation grows quickly, which means regular maintenance is essential to keep the routes accessible. The volunteers spend their working time clearing overgrown sections, removing litter and walking along the trails to monitor their condition.

The work requires energy, and some days are more physically demanding than others. At the same time, it offers the team an opportunity to experience the landscape in a way that would be difficult as ordinary tourists. Walking through forests and following historic paths creates a much closer connection with the places the volunteers are helping to protect.

The experience also highlights a different way of travelling. While many of Europe's most famous destinations are becoming increasingly crowded, rural areas and lesser-known walking routes offer visitors an opportunity to slow down and experience a destination differently.

Instead of rushing from one attraction to another, travellers can walk, observe the landscape and discover communities that are often overlooked by mass tourism. For the Trail Angels, this slower approach has become a natural part of everyday life in Tuscany.

The volunteering experience continues outside the trails as well. The team spends time hiking, cooking, exploring and sharing everyday life as an international group. Volunteers also have opportunities to talk about their experiences and reflect on what it means to live and volunteer in another country.

Some of these conversations have even found their way into podcast episodes, allowing volunteers to share their experiences in their own words and give others a more personal understanding of international volunteering.

Through their work, the Trail Angels are not only helping to care for the paths they walk but also discovering a side of Tuscany that is easy to miss. Sometimes, stepping away from the

most familiar destinations is exactly what allows us to understand a place better.

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Another Trail Angels Adventure Begins

2026 | Tuscany, Italy

In 2026, a new international group of Trail Angels has arrived in Tuscany, ready to continue the project's environmental volunteering activities and contribute to the care of the region's walking routes.

Nature changes constantly, and maintaining outdoor paths is an ongoing process. Weather conditions can leave branches and debris behind, while vegetation can quickly grow across sections of a trail. Litter also continues to appear in places where it should not, creating additional work for those who care for the environment.

This is where the Trail Angels come in. The volunteers work together to clear paths, cut back vegetation, collect rubbish and help keep the routes accessible for walkers and visitors.

The work is practical and sometimes physically demanding, but it also provides an immediate sense of achievement. At the beginning of a volunteering activity, a section of a path may be overgrown or in need of attention. After the team has worked together, the difference can often be clearly seen.

The volunteers may never meet most of the people who will later walk along the paths they have helped to maintain. Nevertheless, knowing that their work can make someone else's journey easier is an important motivation behind the project.

Life outside the volunteering activities is equally important. Sharing a home with people from different countries means constantly learning how to communicate, cooperate and adapt to different habits. The team cooks together, shares household responsibilities and spends its free time discovering Tuscany. Cultural differences sometimes create funny situations, but they also provide countless opportunities to learn from one another.

As the volunteers themselves like to say: "Different countries, same chaos."

Behind that chaos, however, something meaningful happens. People who arrived without knowing one another gradually become a team, creating friendships and memories alongside the practical work they carry out in the local environment.

The trails will continue to change, and new people will continue to walk them. For now, the Trail Angels are doing their part to make sure they remain places that people can enjoy and respect.

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Volunteering Beyond the Trails

2026 | Tuscany, Italy

Environmental action is at the heart of the Trail Angels project, but volunteering often creates opportunities that go far beyond the activities originally planned.

In 2026, another international team of volunteers is contributing to the protection of Tuscany's natural environment. The group takes part in clean-up activities along walking routes and in natural areas, collecting waste and helping to make these places cleaner for local communities, visitors and wildlife.

Removing litter can be demanding work, particularly when large amounts of waste have accumulated over time. However, every bag removed from the environment represents a small but concrete improvement, and working together allows the team to achieve much more than any individual volunteer could do alone.

At the same time, the Trail Angels are becoming involved in the wider community around them. By participating in local volunteering initiatives and supporting community events, the team is discovering that solidarity can take many different forms.

Sometimes volunteering means spending the day outdoors cleaning a trail. On another day, it might mean helping at an event or supporting people who are organising activities for the local community. Being willing to contribute wherever help is needed allows international volunteers to become part of the places where they are staying rather than simply passing through them.

These activities also create opportunities to meet local volunteers and organisations. Young people from different countries find themselves working alongside people who have been supporting their communities for many years. Despite differences in age, nationality or background, they are connected by the same willingness to give their time to something they believe is worthwhile.

The experience also gives the volunteers plenty of opportunities to discover Tuscany and appreciate the environment they are helping to protect. Exploring the region from different perspectives creates a stronger connection with the landscape and a better understanding of why environmental action matters.

Perhaps this is one of the most valuable parts of international volunteering. People often arrive thinking primarily about what they can contribute, but the experience quickly becomes an exchange. Volunteers give their time and energy, while receiving new perspectives, friendships and a sense of connection with communities they may never have

encountered otherwise.

In the end, being a Trail Angel is about more than taking care of trails. It is about being willing to participate, contribute and become part of a community, even if only for a chapter of its story.

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Taking Care of the Paths We Share

2026 | Tuscany, Italy

Another team of Trail Angels is continuing the project's work in Tuscany, bringing together young people from different countries to contribute to the protection of historic walking routes and the surrounding environment.

The volunteers spend much of their working time outdoors, collecting litter and helping to keep the paths clean and accessible. Under the Tuscan sun, the work can sometimes be physically demanding, especially when bags become heavier and there are still kilometres of trail ahead.

This is where teamwork becomes particularly important. Volunteers help each other carry what they have collected, divide responsibilities and work together to complete each activity. Everyone contributes in a different way, and the results come from the combined effort of the whole group.

While working along the trails, the volunteers also encounter the people who use them. Walkers and pilgrims pass through Tuscany for many different reasons. Some are travelling long distances, while others are simply discovering a small section of a historic route.

Even a brief conversation with someone passing by can provide a reminder of why maintaining these paths matters. The work carried out today may make the journey easier or more enjoyable for someone who walks the same route tomorrow.

At the same time, the volunteers themselves are experiencing their own kind of journey. Living together as an international group means learning about different cultures, sharing responsibilities and creating friendships with people they may never have met under ordinary circumstances.

Much of what makes an international volunteering project memorable happens in these everyday moments: preparing dinner together after a long day, talking late into the evening, discovering cultural differences and eventually turning misunderstandings into shared jokes.

The historic routes running through Tuscany have connected people for generations, and they will continue to do so long into the future. The Trail Angels are only one small part of that much larger story.

For now, their role is simple: to walk these paths, take care of them and leave them a little better than they found them.

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